

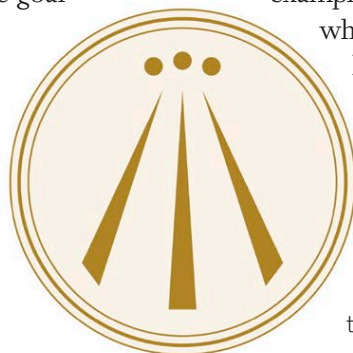


garden, or in a group, in a public place. All take part, regardless of how many people are present. Group rituals often take place in a circle—a sacred ring to enclose and focus the participants—sometimes with a firepit at the center. Alternatively, attention can be directed toward an altar.

The setting is heightened from the everyday norm to stimulate spiritual emotion. Dressing up in appropriate costume, lights, and decorations all help charge the atmosphere. Participants frequently address the compass directions and elements, and invoke spirits—such as Diana, Roman goddess of the moon, when the moon is full. The goal of the ritual, if there is one, is spoken out loud. Depending on beliefs, a drama from the pagan or mythical world may be enacted.

Participants often raise their arms, holding talismans aloft, and chant, sing, and dance around the circle to harness the collective power and energy they believe in. Holding

hands is thought to transfer energy, and the laying on of hands is considered by some to have healing powers. Symbols are important and, on a principle allied to homeopathy (that like cures like), similar objects may be used as substitutes for the real thing. For instance, an image or trinket of a dog can stand for a real dog in a ceremony involving Hecate—the main Greek goddess of magic and a key figure in Neopaganism—as she was sometimes shown in canine form, and dogs were sacrificed to her in ancient times. The principle of substitution is equally applied to colors and numbers—for example, three could be substituted for Hecate, who was a triple-faced deity and could look in three directions at once.



◀ Neodruid symbol

Known as Awen, this is one of the most widely used symbols in Neodruidism. However, there is no consensus on its precise meaning: some believe it represents the sun's rays; others a triple deity.

▲ Beltane

These celebrants are dressed as the Wiccan Horned God for the festival of Beltane, usually held on May 1. One of the Sabbats, Beltane is the cross-quarter day between the spring equinox and the summer solstice. Festivities—which often include bonfires, maypole dances, and fertility magic—celebrate the emerging growth in nature.